with minimal risk. I followed the ball till late and just helped it on the way over the slip fielders, using the pace generated by Ntini.

Virender Sehwag, on his debut, also played aggressively and, had we batted a little better in the second innings, we could have saved the game. Instead, we lost by nine wickets, with Shaun Pollock taking 6–56. My partnership with Sehwag was our high point and I remember asking him if he was nervous when he walked out to bat for the first time in a Test. He admitted that he was a little and I immediately told him that was normal. In fact, it was good to be a little nervous and everyone who played Test cricket experienced similar nerves. He just needed to play his natural game and the nervousness would disappear once he'd spent a little time out in the middle. He did so and scored a fantastic hundred on debut.

Missing the comforts of home

We went to Port Elizabeth for the second Test. Sara and Arjun were both with me and on one evening before the match I asked the hotel staff to recommend a restaurant where we could go out for a good family meal. Eating together was the only way I could spend quality time with my children and I looked forward to these meals at the end of long, hard work days. The hotel staff told me about a diner that also had a fairly big play area where the children could enjoy themselves and we ended up going to the same restaurant three days in a row. It was from this restaurant that I picked up the idea of the play area that I put in my own restaurant when I opened Tendulkar's in Mumbai in 2004.

Food on tour was always an important consideration for the team and to get the kind of food we liked in places such as Bulawayo in Zimbabwe and some South African cities could sometimes be a real problem.

I remember one occasion in Bulawayo when all the players were yearning for home food. We were tired of eating the same breakfast and lunch in the hotel, and the restaurants were not the best. Spotting an Indian family that had come to see us play, Sameer Dighe boldly walked up to them and said that the team was desperate to eat some good Indian food – could they help?

Jhanak bhai, the man in question, was a Gujarati settled in Zimbabwe and he ended up inviting the team to his home, where we feasted on a home-cooked meal of Gujarati-style dal, rice and ghee. We all had three